

Editorial

Don't Touch My Desktop

THEY'RE ALL AROUND, these people who are gushing over the whole multi-touch revolution. Popularised by Apple (with the iPhone and iPod Touch), multi-touch is threatening to take over my desktop with Windows 7, and I don't want it to.

A lot of you will remember *Digit's* coverage of multi-touch, starting with Jefferson Han's TED (ted.com) presentation, Microsoft's Surface, the iPhone, and now Windows 7. Many of you are probably forwarding YouTube links of multi-touch videos to friends, and are really excited. Don't be.

I can understand the desire to have multi-touch on a device such as the iPhone, even if I do hate its on-screen keyboard. I can even understand why people would want it on laptops or tablet PCs, but how am I supposed to find multi-touch beneficial for my desktop?

There are some inherent flaws with the whole multi-touch concept: for starters, until there's significant improvement in natural language processing (NLP), you can forget about ceasing to work with text. Email, spreadsheets, presentations, IMs, web browsing, blogging, coding and more... they're all keyboard-intensive, and account for most of your time spent in front of a computer.

Another aspect to consider is that multi-touch just isn't designed for desktops. Try touching your screen instead of your keyboard every time you want to do something on your PC; bet your arms are aching in 3 minutes. Of course you could argue that you need the touch surface to be the table, not the screen, so lay your large LCD down on the table, and pretend you have Windows 7 (and a touch screen). How long did it take you to tire (or get a backache) this time? 10 minutes?

Precision is another problem when using your fingers — they can't compete with a mouse or a stylus for the kind of accuracy that most design applications or games require.

So is there nothing good about multi-touch? Just as in the videos you've seen, apps such as Google Maps (or Earth), photo viewers, on-screen pianos, video players, liquid simulations, lava lamp apps, etc., will be more intuitive and fun to use. Perhaps a whole new genre of games may arise from it. The possibilities are still limitless, and multi-touch is something that everyone will *enjoy*. Just don't expect to get too much *work* done using multi-touch — not right away at least.

Obviously, Windows 7 is not doing away with keyboards and mice, but that's not what worries me. With laptop prices falling by the minute and Windows 7 pushing multi-touch (and as a result, mobile PCs), are



Robert Sovereign-Smith, Editor

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we looking at a future when *desktops* are niche? This scares me, because although I enjoy the portability of a laptop, I still prefer the sheer power and screen space that only a desktop has to offer.

To fuel conspiracy theorists, remember, doing away with desktops also just happens to be the best form of DRM; most laptops come with (paid) OEM Windows installs, so there will be very little OS piracy to worry about if desktops die. Going by what we know of Windows 7 so far, it isn't radically different from Vista — more like an enhanced Vista with multi-touch support. Vista was able to force a lot of us to upgrade hardware, only to realise that Aero wasn't worth it; so will multi-touch go the Aero way, or will it live up to its over-hyped expectations?

Marketing-hype, a sneaky new DRM or an interface revolution, whatever the case, multi-touch is here to stay.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Robert Sovereign-Smith'.

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